

Sūtra on Taming the Nāga Kings Nanda and Upananda

Nandopananda-nāgarāja-damana-sūtra · Toh 39 · Derge Kangyur

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The Sūtra on Taming the Nāga Kings Nanda and Upananda, known in Sanskrit as the Nandopananda-nāgarāja-damana-sūtra and in Tibetan as Klu'i rgyal po dga' bo nyer dga' gdul ba'i mdo, is a Buddhist sūtra recounting the legendary taming of two powerful nāga kings by the Buddha and his disciples. The text belongs to the narrative sūtra genre and centers on a dramatic episode in which the serpentine nāga lords Nanda and Upananda are subdued through the miraculous powers of the Buddha's retinue, illustrating themes of conversion, the supremacy of the Buddha's wisdom, and the protective role of the Dharma. The story unfolds from the familiar setting of Śrāvastī and the Jeta Grove, grounding it within the broader biographical and legendary literature surrounding Śākyamuni Buddha. It is catalogued as Toh 39 in the Kangyur, where it falls among the general sūtra literature of that collection.

Translated and edited at the great temple Paltharlng (Glorious Liberation Island), the seat of learned scholars, and finalized there.

In the language of India: Nandopananda-nāgarāja-damana-sūtra. In the Tibetan language: the Sūtra on Taming the Nāga Kings Nanda and Upananda.

I bow with reverence to the noble Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada.

At a certain time, the householder Anāthapiṇḍada (the Feeder of the Destitute), having heard the Blessed One teach the Dharma, invited him as a guest, saying: "May the Blessed One together with five hundred monks deign to come to my home tomorrow at midday." The Blessed One consented.

When the remainder of that day had passed, and the night had drawn to its end, at the hour of dawn the Blessed One surveyed with his mind ten thousand world-systems. He then brought to mind the nāga kings called Nanda and Upananda through the door of wisdom. He examined whether there were in them good seeds for definitive benefit, and he saw that they held wrong views and had no faith in the Three Jewels. Having seen this, in order to liberate them from wrong views, he looked upon the great elder Maudgalyāyana as the

one who would tame them.

Then at the hour of dawn, having attended to his bodily ablutions, the Blessed One called the venerable Ānanda and said: "Ānanda, announce to the monks: 'The Blessed One together with five hundred monks has departed for the divine world.'" Ānanda replied, "As the Venerable One commands," and conveyed the matter to the monks.

On that very day, Nanda and Upananda were celebrating a festival of rejoicing. They were seated cross-legged upon divine jewels, holding white divine parasols, surrounded by many nāga retainers and attendants, with nāga males and females performing dances. Divine vessels had been set out nearby, and they were engaged in attending to various kinds of food and drink.

The Blessed One then observed the nāga kings exactly as they were. Having seen what they were doing, the Blessed One, accompanied by five hundred monks, set out directly from above the coiled headdress on the nāga king's head and became visibly present before the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three.

At that time and in that moment, the nāga king Nanda and Upananda, perceiving this situation, fell into sinful views, and a thought of wicked mind arose in them: "These ascetics, having walked across my head, will go from above me up to the realm of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. From this moment on I shall not permit them to scatter the dust of their feet onto my head and depart." He rose and went to the base of Mount Meru. He stretched out his own body and wound it seven times around the entirety of the great mountain from top to bottom, then raised his hood aloft, all in order to prevent the Thirty-Three gods from seeing them.

Then the venerable Viśvāmitra addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable One, as before, while remaining and looking in the direction of this place, I could see the great mountain. I could see the great mountain together with its retinue. I could see the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. I could see the palace of Vaijayanta. I could see the victory banner atop the palace of Vaijayanta. Venerable One, what is the cause and what is the condition that now Mount Meru has become invisible?" The Blessed One declared: "Viśvāmitra, the nāga king called Nanda and Upananda has become enraged at you all. He wound himself seven times around the great mountain with his body and concealed it from above with his raised hood, making it dark and utterly black, and so he remains. Shall I tame him?" The Blessed One had not

yet given permission.

Then the venerable Bhadra and the venerable Rāhula, in order, together with all the monks, made the same request. The Blessed One did not give permission. After all of them, the great elder Maudgalyāyana's son requested: "Venerable One, shall I tame him?" And the Blessed One gave permission, saying: "Maudgalyāyana, tame him."

The elder cast off his own body and transformed himself into the vast body of the nāga king. He wound his body fourteen times around the body of the nāga king Nanda and Upananda, and placed his own hood upon that nāga king's hood. The Blessed One declared: "Press down on Mount Meru and everything around it." And the elder Maudgalyāyana's son did exactly that.

Then the nāga king Nanda and Upananda sent out a stream of smoky breath. The elder likewise breathed out, saying: "You have smoky breath in your body — do I not have it in mine?" The nāga king Nanda and Upananda's smoky breath caused no harm to the elder, but the elder's smoky breath caused harm to the nāga king. The nāga king blazed with fire. The elder likewise set himself alight, saying: "You blaze in your body — do I not do the same?" The nāga king's flames caused no harm to the elder, but the elder's flames caused harm to the nāga king.

The nāga king thought: "This one is surely pressing down on my body, along with Mount Meru and everything around it, and he is producing smoke and fire." He asked: "Who are you?" "I am called Maudgalyāyana." "Venerable One, please abide in your own form."

The elder cast off the nāga body. He entered through the nāga king's right ear canal and came out through the left ear canal. Then he entered through the left ear canal and came out through the right. Similarly, he entered through the right nostril and came out through the left, and then entered through the left nostril and came out through the right. After that, the nāga king's mouth gaped open. The elder entered through the mouth and traversed the belly back and forth, again and again.

The Blessed One declared: "Maudgalyāyana, keep great miraculous power in mind — this nāga is possessed of great miraculous power." The elder replied: "Venerable One, I have cultivated, repeatedly practiced, striven at, established as a foundation, followed through upon, and made myself thoroughly familiar with the four bases of miraculous power. Venerable One, never mind Nanda and Upananda — I am capable of taming a hundred like them, a thousand like

them, even a hundred thousand like them."

The nāga king thought: "This one moving about inside me I cannot see. When he comes out, I shall catch him between my two fangs." He said: "Venerable One, come out — what is the point of moving about and staying inside my belly again and again?" The elder came out and stood there. The nāga king saw him and thought: "Is this he?" and blew a blast of air from his nostrils. But the elder, having attained all four meditative concentrations, could not be budged even from a single pore by that blast from the nostrils.

As for the other monks: while they were capable of performing all the miraculous feats of the earlier ones, they were not able to quickly attain all four meditative concentrations once they had entered those states. It was for this reason that the Blessed One had not given those others permission to tame the nāga king. The nāga king thought: "This monk is of great miraculous power, since even a single pore of his could not be stirred by the blast of my nostrils."

The elder then cast off the monk's form and —

manifested himself in the form of a garuḍa (garuḍa), the splendid-winged bird. Upon seeing the garuḍa's body, the nāga king fled. Hot on the garuḍa's heels, the nāga king cast off his own form and appeared in the guise of a brahmin youth, saying, "Venerable one, I take refuge in you," and prostrated at the elder's feet. The elder, having tamed the nāga king and rendered him harmless, said, "Come, let us go before the Teacher," and led him into the presence of the Blessed One.

The nāga king bowed before the Blessed One and said, "Venerable one, I take refuge in you." The Blessed One declared, "Excellent!" and then, together with his retinue of monks, proceeded to the dwelling of Anāthapiṇḍada (Anāthapiṇḍada, the great lay patron "Feeder of the Destitute").

Anāthapiṇḍada asked, "Venerable one, why have you not come for so long?" The Blessed One replied, "Mahāmaudgalyāyana (Mahāmaudgalyāyana) and Nanda-Sunanda (Nanda and Sunanda) were engaged in combat." When Anāthapiṇḍada asked, "Venerable one, who was defeated and who was victorious?" the Blessed One replied, "The householder Mahāmaudgalyāyana was victorious; Nanda-Sunanda was defeated."

Anāthapiṇḍada then requested permission to offer the Blessed One the midday meal for seven days in due succession, and to render honor and

service to the elder. He further requested to render honor and service for seven days to the five hundred monks beginning with the buddhas — that is, the accomplished ones — of the community.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, those monks rejoiced in what the Blessed One had said.

The Sūtra of Taming the Nāga King Nanda-Sunanda is complete.

From the mouth of the great paṇḍita Ānandaśrī, it was translated by the śrāvaka monk of the Śākya order, Nyima Gyaltsen Palsangpo, learned in much scripture, speaker of two languages —

Translator's Notes

- The text opens with a colophon-like statement indicating the place of translation and editing, the great temple Paltharlng. This precedes the sūtra's Sanskrit title and its Tibetan rendering.

The name Anāthapiṇḍada is rendered with its meaning in parentheses on first occurrence, as it is an epithet rather than an opaque proper name; it literally means "Feeder of the Destitute" and is the standard designation of the householder who donated the Jeta Grove.

The final sentence is ambiguous: the Tibetan reads that the Blessed One had not given permission, which could mean either that Maudgalyāyana had not yet received permission to proceed, or that the Blessed One declined. Given the narrative context, in which Maudgalyāyana is subsequently sent to tame the nāgas, the most natural reading is that the Blessed One had not yet granted permission at that precise moment, leaving it as a narrative pause rather than a refusal.

The phrase rendered "coiled headdress" refers to the coiled hood or crown of a nāga king's serpentine form, which is the natural meaning of the term here.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the passage, with the elder having cast off the monk's form and about to transform again; this is a continuation point, not a translation uncertainty.

The Tibetan for "the four bases of miraculous power" renders the standard Skt. ṛddhipāda, here simply rendered by its conventional doctrinal description rather than inserting the Sanskrit term parenthetically, as it is a well-established formula.

- The phrase "five hundred monks beginning with the buddhas" is unusual and likely refers to the fully accomplished arhats at the head of the monastic assembly; in context, "buddhas" here functions as an honorific designation for the senior arhats, not literally the Awakened Ones. The Tibetan "sang s rgyas la sogs pa'i dge slong lnga brgya" most naturally reads as "the five hundred monks beginning with [those called] buddhas," which may reflect a specific designation within this narrative's community.

The colophon is incomplete as the passage ends mid-sentence with "speaker of two languages," indicating the translation breaks off here.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.